Southeast Asian spice trade. In 1611, the English had established a foothold at the Golconda port of Masulipatnam, but natural and political circumstances proved adverse. In 1639, a small plot was negotiated in the village of Madraspatnam (later Madras, present-day Chennai) next to a Portuguese establishment at San Thome, and in the 1630s, Company representatives were sent to Bengal to secure food and raw materials. Initially, European trade with the eastern coast of India was the responsibility of centres in Southeast Asia—the Portuguese in Malacca, the Dutch in Jakarta, and the English at Bantam—because textiles from India helped service the spice trade. Only later did the English consolidate their presence in Madras and Bengal. This included the foundation under somewhat chaotic circumstances of a fort near the village of Kalighat (Calcutta) by an idiosyncratic Company agent named Job Charnock. [67]

On the west coast of India, the English arrived in Surat in 1607 in a bid to diversify trade by tapping the Arabian Sea network. It also became a point of interaction with the Mughal court in Agra. In 1612, the Company won a small but decisive naval victory over the Portuguese off the Gujarat coast, and Emperor Jehangir eventually allowed the English to establish a trading post at Surat. Bombay came into English hands as part of a dowry and defence treaty with Portugal in 1661, as alliances shifted. The complete defeat of the English to a Mughal naval force led by Sidi Yaqub in Bombay in 1689 led to a temporary shift of their operations back to Surat. But Emperor Aurangzeb allowed the English to remain in Bombay under ‘humiliating’ conditions. [68]

As late as 1750, the British political and military presence in India was still quite modest. It consisted of several factories—major ones in Madras, Bombay and Calcutta, which were the bases of three ‘Presidencies’—and a few hundred English soldiers. The industrial revolution had not yet occurred and, economically, India still dwarfed England. However, the Company managed to establish its dominance among Europeans in the Indian Ocean by marginalizing the Portuguese and Dutch in a series of conflicts and establishing an effective monopoly on trade in several goods. By the eighteenth century, their primary European rivals for influence in